

screen even at a distance of half to a quarter meter away. The Kodak mc3 had the worst LCD screen, which was pitch black when turned on, and absolutely nothing was visible even when held in front of a light source. Clicking photographs with this camera is absolute guesswork.

On the other hand, cameras such as the Intel Pocket camera and D-link's Digi-link didn't have an LCD screen but a small LCD display at the top which displayed the number of snaps taken and other settings such as flash on/off, burst mode, etc.

Software and drivers: Any digital camera is incomplete without the software, which is required to download the image on the PC. Some low-end cameras such as the Intel Pocket Camera were bundled with the best software, which could not only download the images and video clips but also edit and optimise them for the Web. Also included were games based on the concept of motion detection, a totally new concept available only in Intel cameras. You can connect the camera to your PC and start a game of, say basketball. You then move your hand in front of the camera and the ball actually bounces according to your hand movements.

The Kodak mc3 was another camera with good bundled software that detects the camera the moment it is connected to your PC. The software starts downloading the images automatically and even displays the battery status for a few seconds while the download is in progress. High-end cameras such as the Kodak DC-3400 came with the ArcSoft PhotoImpression software, which is really simple to use and easy to understand. The Canon PowerShot A10 came with useful software such as PhotoStich 3.1, using which you can stitch all your photographs in a linear strip and view them by just scrolling across.

CONCLUSION

In the higher end category the clear winner was the **Sony DCS-P1** 3.3 mega pixel camera. The camera was loaded with features such as taking snaps in black and white and sepia mode, adjusting white balance, etc, coupled with ease of navigation. Although it did not produce the best results in terms of image clarity, it did extremely well in the resolution test.

Runners up was the Kodak DC-4800. This 3.3 mega pixel camera did well in the entire test but lost to Sony only in terms of features. This camera shone in picking up details but gave a grainy overall image. Canon IXUS came third in the shoot out.

This camera did well in picking up details and even produced colour well, except that it showed dark areas in the image, wherever light was low. It came with a detailed manual, good bundled software and rechargeable batteries, which helped it score in the feature test. The Canon IXUS was one of the lightest and good-looking cameras in its category.

Among the low-end cameras, **Intel** emerged the winner. This camera had excellent bundled software with a very clean interface and was very easy to use. The camera also had a host of features such as the ability to store up to 824 MB of video directly on the hard drive, and a computer game.

The second in this category was Kodak EZ200, which worked as both digital camera and Web cam. Although it did not give good results in indoor photographs with poor light conditions, the outdoor



Sony DCS-P1: Good all-round performance



Intel Pocket PC camera: Truly worth it

photographs were of good quality at 640x480 pixels.

If you are looking at a camera that gives good quality output at a reasonable price, then what you should seek is the Kodak DC-3400. Amongst the cameras with lower resolution the Intel is the best buy as the camera can work as a digital camera and Web cam, record video and all this under Rs 10,000. 

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